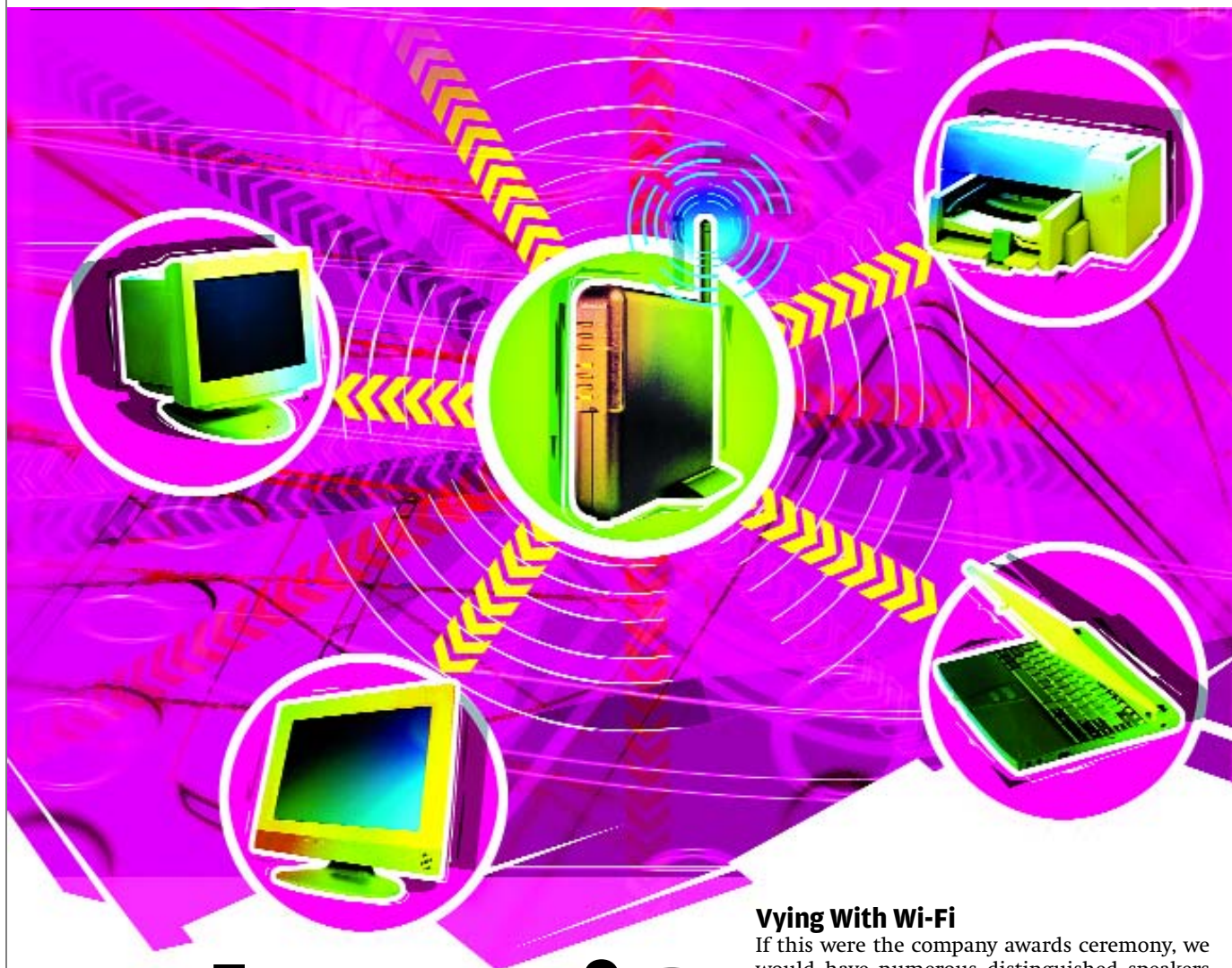




Why-Fi?

That's the question most medium-sized businesses are asking themselves...

Robert Sovereign-Smith

Computers invaded us, and won. The very nature of businesses today demands mobility and instant, anywhere access to critical information. While the Internet has given us this much-required data mobility on a global scale, the same does not hold true within our own offices. Unfortunately, the desktop has been the ruling party so far, and mobile devices are only just gaining popularity.

We tend not to realise how chained we are to our seats at work. Executives jet across the world, access their e-mails in airports worldwide, meet with clients in hotels and restaurants, and download presentations; yet, within their own offices, they are confined to a 4 x 6 foot space called a cubicle—and all because of a short wire with an RJ45 connector on one end. Networking, the bane of mobility!

Vying With Wi-Fi

If this were the company awards ceremony, we would have numerous distinguished speakers gushing superlatives, introducing the persona that single-handedly revolutionised mobile computing. Yes, that's perhaps the most apt introduction to Wi-Fi. Without it, every mobile device, from laptops to PDAs, would be nothing more than external hard drives—absolutely useless on their own, but great for transporting data from one network to another.

But should all businesses set up a Wi-Fi network? If only it were that simple! New companies have no problem deciding: Wi-Fi is the way to go—the setup is quick, easy and affordable, and shifting offices is as easy as packing and unpacking the equipment. However, existing businesses really have to weigh the mobility offered against the costs. If you have a huge inventory management setup, and lots of employees using equipment such as laptops and barcode scanners, you should seriously consider Wi-Fi as an option.

I'm Sold. What Now?

You need to do a site survey, and then decide upon the number of access points you need in order to be able to provide seamless network coverage. You also need to keep in mind that there's no such thing as a true wireless LAN (WLAN) with no trace of wires. Your servers and access points need to be connected via a regular wired LAN to give them the connection